

and has been the addressing system on the Internet since. What the DNS does is to establish a hierarchy of domains, which are groups of computers on the Internet. The DNS gives each computer on the Net an address, or domain name, using easily-recognisable letters and words instead of numbers. Each top-level domain maintains the lists and addresses of the second-level domain, and so on. The letters or word you see before the dot of the gTLD is called the “second-level domain” (like “google” in “www.google.com”). The second-level domain is usually chosen by the organisation that owns the computer.

As an example of how the DNS and domains work, let us consider the example of [www.thinkdigit.com](http://www.thinkdigit.com). The top domain here is .com, which stands for commercial organisation (not governmental, educational, etc.). The www below the sub-domain name is by far the most commonly-used, as it refers to the organisation’s Web server, that is, the computer that stores all the organisation’s Web pages.

What you pride as your e-mail ID is constructed in a similar way. Take the example [xyz@yahoo.co.in](mailto:xyz@yahoo.co.in). The first part of the address—to the left of the @ sign—is the username. This is what the person called xyz—or who would like to be identified as xyz—will use to log in to his Internet account. The second part of the address—the letters to the right of the @ sign—is the domain name or hostname. This identifies the specific computer where the person has an Internet e-mail account (e.g. a mail server). If the e-mail account is located at the person’s workplace, this host or domain name would be the same as the name of the company (like [xyz@bbc.co.uk](mailto:xyz@bbc.co.uk)). Else, it will reflect where the person has an Internet account—an ISP or online service. So, a closer look at the example [xyz@yahoo.co.in](mailto:xyz@yahoo.co.in) when read from right to left tells every computer on the Internet to route data to...

The zone in which the host server is located (.in = India)

The nature of the organisation (.co = commercial)

The service that provides the e-mail service (yahoo)

The username of the user (xyz)

### 2.1.13 The Process explained, but shortly

Let’s move on to analyse the situation a little deeper. How exactly